FUGUE XII

THE character of this lively Fugue has probably never been mistaken. But the structure has been known to rouse the wrath of theorists who prefer to remain unaware that Bach devoted the entire first four Fugues of *Die Kunst der Fuge* to a didactic demonstration that even on a severely plain Subject, primarily designed for the utmost complexities of combination with itself and other counterpoints, it is possible for a Fugue to enjoy life without Stretti, without Double Counterpoint, without Inversion, and without anything but well-timed entries of its Subject in the course of a happy flow of Episodes. The seven Fugues in *Das Wohltemperirte Klavier* that support life on these terms have very lively Subjects, as is natural where Bach is not compelling himself to use the same theme for the simplest as well as the most complex designs. In the present instance nothing can be more obvious than the recurrence of characteristic Episodes, with their increasing brilliance in position and detail. It is worth, however, noticing that the indefinitely flowing Episode 1 (occurring, according to Bach's usual practice, before the entry of the third voice, bars 8-11) is reproduced in idea (bars 45-50), thereby giving relief to the highly formal effect of the four appearances of the amusingly characteristic Episode 2 (bars 17-24).

The mordent given by the best MSS. (including an autograph) to the Subject gives the modern listener a pleasant sense of the date of this comedy, and rather adds to its liveliness. It may therefore be supplied where not unplayable (it must be very short and sharp) to other entries, and may serve (like a Highlander's whoop) to mark off the real Subject from the episodic development in bars 56-65 (a new episodic line not found elsewhere in the Fugue).

In bar 53 Bach gives the bass a rest for practical reasons. Nägeli (the publisher who put four bars into one of Beethoven's Sonatas and sent him the proof-copy) supplies the figure  There is no harm in this, if it can be played decently. On the clavichord even a large hand makes but a rough job of it; and even on the pianoforte there is more æsthetic interest in Bach's practical common sense.

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